How to Bargain with a Dragon

By R. L. Stine

Suggested Roles: ***Actor 1*** *– Narrator 1, Ned, Margolin*
Actor 2 *-- Narrator 2, Gregory, Sir Darkwind, Ulrick (the Dragon)*

NOTE: This cutting asks each student to portray multiple characters, which is permissible for Nationals and SOME states. It may not meet the rules requirement for DUO

NARRATOR 2: **(Pgs 41-47)** On a summer day long ago, when birds as big as clouds flew the skies, a boy named Ned journeyed through leafy forests and over green, grassy hills. *(Ned whistles while he walks)* Soon he would be meeting Sir Darkwind, the greatest Dragon Master in the kingdom. Ned had long dreamed of this day. Through the trees, he heard the dragons in Sir Darkwind's stable. *(dragon noises, Ned stops whistling an appears intimidated)* And Ned wondered which would prove more fierce and menacing—the dragons or the Dragon Master?

INTRODUCTION

ACTOR 1: *This story begins with a question: What if dragons were real?*
ACTOR 2: *In literature and movies, dragons are fierce and majestic; ugly and beautiful; and* ***much*** *more intelligent than dinosaurs.*
ACTOR 1: *Dragons have been a part of storytelling and mythology for centuries.*
ACTOR 2: *Remember The Jabberwocky?! Lewis Carroll's "ferocious dragon with jaws that bite, claws that clutch, and great eyeballs of fire."*
ACTOR 1: *And who can forget Daenerys Targaryen? All she has to do is say "Dracarys" and her fire-breathing companions lay waste to entire armies and cities.*
ACTOR 2: *Now, I know dragons never existed, but the ones I battle in Dungeons and Dragons – seem mighty real to me!*
ACTOR 1: *But what if they did exist? Ned certainly believes they do. He's on a terrifying quest to face the fiercest dragon of them all!*
ACTOR 2: *Roll for initiative, Ned! (rolls dice) 17!*
ACTOR 1: *How to Bargain with a Dragon*
ACTOR 2: *from The Haunting Hour by R.L. Stine*

NED: *(murmuring to himself)* Courage. Be strong and brave. Or you will never reach your goal. *(takes deep breath, then a step and, shielding his eyes he looks up . . . way up)*

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NARRATOR 2: A tall stone wall at least four times as tall as Ned rose up like a gleaming mountain in the afternoon sun. Ned gazed in amazement at the faces staring back at him from above the top of the wall. Broad creature faces on long, scaly necks. Black eyes as big as plums, staring from deep sockets. Ancient, long-toothed faces, craggy and lined with wisdom—and sadness.

NED: Dragons!

NARRATOR 2: Gazing at the amazing creatures, Ned remembered the Sorcerer's stories of how the dragons had once moved freely around the kingdom.

MARGOLIN: Do not be fooled into thinking they are like other animals. Their wisdom is as big as their size. Why are their eyes so sad? Because they have seen everything.

NED: *(cupping his hands around his mouth and shouting)* Sir Darkwind! Sir Darkwind, a humble peasant boy wishes to speak with you. *(a door creaks open)*

GREGORY: *(from the doorway in a high, boyish voice)* What do you want?

NED: I have come to see the great Dragon Master. To ask a favor.

GREGORY: I am Gregory, Sir Darkwind's servant. Sir Darkwind does no favors.

NED: *(swallows)* I bring the best wishes of the great Sorcerer Margolin. If Sir Darkwind would come outside and give me a moment—

GREGORY: *(sneering)* We don't know any sorcerers, and Sir Darkwind only comes out of his house to whip the dragons -- keep them in their place.

NED: He never leaves his house?

GREGORY: No, he has too many enemies. *(dragons growl and groan)*

SIR DARKWIND: *(deep voice bellows offstage)* Go away! You are upsetting the dragons! *(he steps to the doorway)*

NARRATOR 1: Sir Darkwind was the cruelest man in the kingdom. Even the Sorcerer Margolin, with all his powerful magic, had feared him.

NED: *(drops to his knees and bows his head)* Are you the great Dragon Master? I am a humble peasant boy, grand sir. I come to beg for work. I was apprenticed to the Sorcerer Margolin, but after Margolin had a terrible argument with another sorcerer, they both suddenly

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vanished.

SIR DARKWIND: Good riddance! The world doesn't need sorcerers. A good strong whip is the only magic I need! *(cracks his whip)* These are the last dragons -- The last in the world.

NED: *(fearfully rises)* I would be honored to help tend to them.

SIR DARKWIND: You would swing the whip to help teach them their manners? *(cracks his whip; dragons growl and groan)*

NED: No, sir. But—

SIR DARKWIND: What then is your bargain? All of life is a bargain. So what bargain do you wish to make with me?

NED: I have no answer. I offer myself as a humble worker.

SIR DARKWIND: I have a bargain for you. There is one dragon still roaming free. One dragon not in my collection. And I want them all! ***All***! *(cackles maniacally)* Bring me last free dragon and I will make you my apprentice.

NED: Capture a dragon? But how? I have no weapon to use against a mighty dragon!

SIR DARKWIND: You must use your wits, boy. The last free dragon is called Ulrick. It lives in a cave on top of Stone Hill. *(exit, slamming the door)*

NARRATOR 1: Stone Hill, a steep-sloped mountain of smooth gray rock, led to a high cliff. Deep caves were cut into the sides of the hill. ***No one*** explored those caves. People were afraid of the fierce creatures that lived inside.

NED: *(walking through the forest toward Stone Hill)* What weapon can I use to battle a dragon? It will have talons a foot long and teeth the size of tree stumps. How can I make a bargain with a dragon like that?

NARRATOR 2: By the time Ned reached the top of the hill, his heart was thudding and his legs felt heavy as lead. *(Ned struggles to catch his breath)* He gazed at the cave opening. Enormous bones, bleached white by the sun, were strewn at the entrance. *(a bellowing roar from deep in the cave)*

NED: *(to himself)* I have no choice. I have to go through with this. *(long, deep breath, then he yells)* Ulrick—my name is Ned, and I have come to see you!

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NARRATOR 2: The ground shook as a giant creature burst out and rose over Ned. A dragon bigger and more fierce than any in Sir Darkwind's collection. Leathery wings flapped furiously on its back. Hot yellow drool splashed from its open maw and sizzled on the ground.

ULRICK: *(bellowing)* WHAT DO YOU WANT?

NED: *(trying to shield himself with both hands)* You—you talk?

ULRICK: Of course! All dragons speak when there is something to say!

NED: *(terror fading, cautiously)* Ulrick, why do you stay by yourself up here? Are you not lonely? Why don't you join the other dragons down below?

ULRICK: *(bitterly)* Do you know anything about the Dragon Master, Ned? All my brothers and sisters used to roam free, in peace. We are no threat to humans. We eat only the Gorsel bushes. The great Dragon Master destroyed all the gorsel bushes except his own! The dragons had a choice—starve or be captured. As soon as the dragons followed him home, Sir Darkwind clipped their wings. *(anger growing)* He whips them and keeps them penned up. He charges a fee to see them. And he forces the dragons to roar and battle each other for the crowds. *(roars)*

NARRATOR 1: The mighty dragon roared and raged.

ULRICK: You want to capture ME and add ME to Sir Darkwind's sad collection? NEVER! NEVER!

NED: NO! WAIT! PLEASE! NOOOOOO!

NARRATOR 2: And then the dragon lifted him easily off the ground. *(Ned thrashes and squirms)* The dragon tilted its head back to swallow him.

NED: WAIT! I'LL MAKE YOU A BARGAIN! *(dragon pauses, turns his head and listens as Ned whispers)*

******** The Next Morning – Sir Darkwind's castle *******

GREGORY: *(empties a water bucket into the dragons' trough, he hears a sound behind him and let's out a startled cry)* D-D-D-Dragon! Sir Darkwind! Sir Darkwind! A dragon approaches!

NARRATOR 1: An enormous dragon was lumbering toward Sir Darkwind's house, swinging

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its head from side to side, wings fluttering on its back.

SIR DARKWIND: *(rushing to the door)* It is Ulrick coming to join the others! (laughs cruelly) Ulrick probably had the boy for breakfast!

GREGORY: But then why has the dragon come here?

SIR DARKWIND: *(giving Gregory a hard push)* Go see at once—while I wait in the safety of the house.

GREGORY: *(legs trembling, approaches Ulrick and shouts up to him, voice cracking with fear)* Ulrick—the Dragon Master demands to know: Why have you come?

NARRATOR 1: With a sudden motion the huge dragon swung down its head. *(Gregory gasps and leaps back)* And then slowly, very slowly, the dragon opened its massive jaws.

GREGORY: *(peers inside the dragon's mouth and moans)* Oh, nooooo!

NARRATOR 1: He saw the boy's head inside the dragon's mouth. The head, eyes shut, rested on the creature's fat red tongue.

GREGORY: *(shouting)* You have eaten him! You have eaten the boy! *(he spins around)* Sir Darkwind! You must come and see this! You must come at once! *(faints)*

NARRATOR 1: The Dragon Master cautiously stepped out of the house and strode up to the dragon. He saw the boy's head, dark hair matted wetly to his forehead. And saw the boy's peacefully shut eyes.

SIR DARKWIND: *(defiantly)* Did you think that would shock me? You have wasted your time, Ulrick! *(cracks his whip)*

NED: *(from his death pose, he pops up from the dragon's mouth, brushing back his hair and wiping dragon drool from his smock)* I do not think so. I knew this would get you out of the house!

SIR DARKWIND: *(eyes wide with surprise)* How—how have you done this, boy?

NED: I made a bargain with the dragon, just as you instructed me.

SIR DARKWIND: And now the dragon is mine?

NED: Not quite. That isn't the bargain. You see, before the Sorcerer Margolin disappeared, he taught me many of his spells. I'm going to show you one of my favorites. *(waves his hands*

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and mumbles strange-sounding words)

NARRATOR 2: And the Dragon Master began to change. His face sank into his body. Leafy limbs sprouted all around him. And bright-red berries popped out around the leaves. The spell had worked! Ned had turned Sir Darkwind into . . . a Gorsel bush.

NED: *(to audience)* My mission was to destroy the Dragon Master and free the dragons. But first I had to trick him into leaving the house! As you can see, I have succeeded.

SIR DARKWIND: *(waves his leafy arms, and makes terrified noises)*

ULRICK: You have kept your bargain with me. How long will your spell last?

NED: It doesn't really matter—does it?

ULRICK: No, not really. *(smiling a huge toothy grin)* [As I told you before] . . . We eat ***only*** the Gorsel bushes. *(takes a huge bite of Sir Darkwind)*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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